unanswered questions were documented as meticulously as the rest of the understood portions. Compiling the daily reports from team members, and the papers the SEP administration gave us (all in French), I maintained three copies of the ever-expanding Vernon Document. After translating to English, one was sent to India through the diplomatic mail, and a backup team headed by T P Rangamani reviewed them, asked for clarifications, updated them and filed them away for posterity. The second one was sent raw, in French. The third one I kept. This document where we discussed in the minutest of detail every component, down to the nuts and bolts, remains a Bible for anyone working on PSLV or GSLV.

Now, as I grappled with the Gowarikar-Muthunayagam fight while continuing to develop the Vikas engine, the Vernon Document was dusted and developed upon, to plug the holes and crack the unanswered questions through indigenisation of materials and fabrication. That is where MIDHANI after much persuasion, delivered.

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Given that I was caught between an indifferent boss and a scheming super boss between 1979 and 1983, I considered it quite a feat to have put together the Vikas engine. Of course, this wouldn't have been possible without Dhawan having faith in me.

ISRO had by now tasted success of its first Satellite Launch Vehicle, SLV-3. For Kalam, this was the fruition of some long, hard labour and Dhawan's unflinching trust in him. The first flight of SLV-3 on 10 August 1979 was a failure. The next launch, carrying Rohini RS-1 satellite on 18 July 1980 was a success. The aftermath of these two launches were to become a subject of Kalam's speeches in the later years when he scaled new heights and went on to become the President of India.

Kalam would recollect these days in his speeches and interviews, extolling the virtues of a leader. On 10 August 1979, media from across the world had gathered at the Sriharikota spaceport for a press meet soon after the scheduled launch early morning. Moments after the rocket plunged into the Bay of Bengal due to a valve failure, Dhawan addressed the media, owning up for the failure